

The warning signs across the attacks that target people, and the one move that beats them.

60%

of breaches involve the human element

Verizon DBIR 2025

\$2.77B

reported losses to business email compromise in 2024

FBI IC3 2024

21 sec

median time to click a phishing link

Verizon DBIR 2024

EMAIL AND MESSAGE LURES (PHISHING)

- 01

Urgency and pressure

Act now, this expires, do not tell anyone. Real requests survive a pause.
- 02

A sender that almost matches

Look-alike domains, a reply-to that differs, a display name that spoofs someone you know.
- 03

Verify your account links

A login page reached from a message, not from your own bookmark or typed address.

PHONE AND VOICE (VISHING)

- 04

A call that manufactures urgency

IT, a bank, or a manager who needs you to act before you have time to think.
- 05

Requests to read a code aloud

No legitimate caller ever needs the one-time code on your screen.
- 06

Pressure not to hang up and check

Discouraging a callback is the tell. Hang up and call a known number.

IMPERSONATION AND DEEPPAKES

- 07

A familiar face or voice pushing a transfer

A senior leader on video asking for an urgent, secret payment or login.
- 08

Audio and video that drift

Lip-sync that lags, odd blinking, flat lighting, or a voice slightly off.
- 09

Camera or mic problems on cue

Quality drops the moment you ask a hard or unexpected question.

AUTHENTICATION ATTACKS (MFA AND AITM)

- 10

An MFA prompt you did not start

Approving a push you did not request hands your live session to the attacker.
- 11

A login reached through a link

Adversary-in-the-middle pages relay your real login and steal the session token.

PAYMENT AND AUTHORITY

- 12

New payment details by message

Wire changes, gift cards, crypto, or new bank details that arrive in a message or call.
- 13

Requests to bypass process

Just this once, skip the second approver, keep it quiet.
- 14

Authority used to skip the check

A name, a title, or a logo deployed to make you waive the normal step.

THE ONE MOVE

The one move that beats most of them: stop and verify on a channel you chose. Call back on a known number, open the site from your own bookmark, confirm with the person directly. The attacker is counting on you not to pause.

Sources: Verizon Data Breach Investigations Report (2024, 2025); FBI IC3 2024 Annual Report. Figures as publicly reported.

How this is made: threat level: human is an AI-assisted production. A real person researches every story, checks each claim against primary sources, and is accountable for the facts.